LOCALIZATION PM PRIMER

The Nine Disciplines of Localization Project Management

● LINGUISTIC ARTS ● TECHNICAL PROCESS ● MANAGEMENT & DELIVERY

I — *The Magician*

THE MEMORY KEEPER

Translation Memory & TM Leverage

> *"The PM who does not build memory builds debt."*

TM stores every approved segment. 100% matches cost nothing; 75–99% fuzzy matches are discounted; new words pay full rate. Run word count analysis before every quote — never estimate.

memoQ · Smartcat · SDL Trados · Phrase TMS

II — *The High Priestess*

THE QUALITY SENTINEL

Linguistic Quality Assurance

> *"Quality is not the absence of errors. It is the presence of judgment."*

LQA applies MQM or LISA scoring to translated content. Error categories: accuracy, fluency, terminology, style, locale conventions. Scored and weighted before release — not after.

MQM · LISA QA · xBench · Error typology

III — *The Fool*

THE SHADOW TEST

Pseudotranslation & i18n Testing

> *"Test the shadow before you commit to the shape."*

Pseudotranslation replaces source strings with placeholder characters to expose text expansion, truncation, encoding errors, and RTL issues before real translation begins. Runs before linguistic work.

CAT pseudotranslation · i18n lint · Encoding check

IV — *The Chariot*

THE IRON SCRIBE

Machine Translation Post-Editing

> *"The machine is fast. The judgment is yours."*

MTPE-F (full) for publication-quality output; MTPE-L (light) for gist and internal use. Content tiering determines engine and level. Legal and medical content is never MTPE-L.

DeepL · ModernMT · Lara · MTQE · Content tiering

V — *The Hermit*

THE FOG OF SIMILARITY

Fuzzy Match Thresholds & WC Analysis

> *"The fog is not the enemy. The PM who cannot read it is."*

Fuzzy bands: 100% (no cost), 95–99% (5–15%), 85–94% (25–40%), 75–84% (50–60%), new words (100%). Run actual analysis before every quote. A budget built on estimates is not a budget.

CAT WC reports · Cost modelling · Band discounts

VI — *The Empress*

THE KEEPER OF TERMS

Linguistic Asset Management

> *"A termbase ignored is a termbase that does not exist."*

Linguistic assets: TMs, termbases, style guides, brand voice docs. Built centrally, enforced via QA rules in the CAT tool. Handed over at every vendor briefing. Maintained after every project cycle.

MultiTerm · Smartcat TB · Style guide governance

VII — *The Hierophant*

THE GUILD MASTER

Vendor Management & LSP Briefing

> *"The brief is not a formality. It is the contract before the contract."*

LSP briefing covers: scope, tone, audience, domain, key terms, prohibited terms, references, SLA, QA expectations, escalation path. Two sentences is not a brief. Preferred vendor lists and KPI tracking are programme-level tools.

RFP/RFQ · SLA design · KPI tracking · PVL

VIII — *Justice*

THE TRIAL OF LANGUAGES

Localization Testing (In-Context Review)

> *"Testing is not the last step. It is the proof of every step before it."*

In-context review tests strings in the live UI. Bug severity: critical (breaks function), major (wrong meaning), minor (style). RTL, pseudolocalization, and linguistic testing are separate tracks. Integrates into sprint cycles.

Bug severity matrix · Jira · RTL testing · ICR

IX — *The World*

THE CROSSING OF WORLDS

Cultural Adaptation & Transcreation

> *"Translation moves words. Transcreation moves people."*

Transcreation brief: source intent, target emotion, cultural constraints, back-translation requirement, approval path. Used for slogans, campaign copy, brand voice. Not interchangeable with standard translation.

Transcreation brief · Back-translation · hreflang

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QUICK REFERENCE

THREE STAGES · SIX FIELD RULES · FOUR ORACLE QUOTES

LINGUISTIC ARTS

I · Translation Memory
II · Linguistic Quality Assurance
III · Pseudotranslation & i18n

Foundation of quality.
The work before the work.

TM · Fuzzy Matches · MQM · LISA QA
Text Expansion · RTL · Encoding

TECHNICAL PROCESS

IV · MTPE
V · Fuzzy Match Thresholds
VI · Linguistic Asset Management

The engine room.
Cost, speed, and precision.

DeepL · ModernMT · MTQE
Word Count · Band Analysis · Termbase

MANAGEMENT & DELIVERY

VII · Vendor Management
VIII · Localization Testing
IX · Transcreation

Programme ownership.
Relationship and judgment.

LSP Brief · RFP · SLA · KPI
In-Context Review · Transcreation Brief

THE PM'S FIELD RULES

Never quote without running a TM analysis first.
A budget built on assumptions is not a budget. The real match rate is rarely what you expect.

The LSP brief is the most important document you produce.
Two sentences is not a brief. Scope, tone, terms, SLA, and escalation path — minimum.

Content tiering determines MT quality — not word count.
Legal and medical content is never MTPE-L. Internal comms can be. Decide before briefing.

Pseudotranslation runs before linguistic translation.
Find the layout bugs before the translators find them for you. Fix them in the source.

Linguistic assets are handed over at every briefing.
A termbase that is not shared does not exist. Governance is not optional.

In-context review is a separate track from LQA.
String correctness and UI correctness are different problems. Both tracks must run.

THE ORACLE SPEAKS

"The PM who does not build memory builds debt."

ARCANA I · THE MEMORY KEEPER

"Quality is not the absence of errors. It is the presence of judgment."

ARCANA II · THE QUALITY SENTINEL

"The brief is not a formality. It is the contract before the contract."

ARCANA VII · THE GUILD MASTER

"Translation moves words. Transcreation moves people."

ARCANA IX · THE CROSSING OF WORLDS

The complete interactive oracle — with real-life examples, scenario modals, and the full summoning — lives at

theoracleoflocalization.online

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